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Proof, not policy: forced labour evidence for Turkish suppliers to EU buyers

The EU ban on products made with forced labour applies from 14 December 2027. Buyers are already asking suppliers what they can show.

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Executive summary

1. Regulation (EU) 2024/3015 prohibits placing on the EU market, making available or exporting any product made wholly or partly with forced labour. It applies from 14 December 2027, and the European Commission published guidelines on 30 June 2026.
2. The ban applies to products, not companies, and has no size threshold. A product found to be tainted can be withdrawn and disposed of at the operator's expense, and good due diligence does not by itself prevent a prohibition.
3. For Turkish suppliers in long, labour-intensive chains, such as garments and textiles or products with seasonal agricultural labour, the commercial question is simple: when an EU buyer asks for traceability and labour evidence, can we provide it quickly and credibly?

What has changed

The Forced Labour Regulation was published at the end of 2024 and applies from 14 December 2027. It covers all products, of any origin, sold in or exported from the EU, regardless of how small the affected share of the product is. Services are excluded.

The Commission leads investigations where the suspected forced labour takes place outside the EU, and national authorities lead for risks inside the EU. Authorities prioritise by scale and severity, the volume of products concerned and the importance of the affected input. They can rely on a wide range of evidence, and an operator's failure to provide information can count against it.

Where forced labour is established, authorities order that the product is not placed on or exported from the market and is withdrawn, with disposal in principle at the operator's expense. The prohibition attaches to the product, so it cannot simply be sold through another channel. There is no exemption for stock already in warehouses on 14 December 2027.

The June 2026 guidelines explain the scope, the definition of forced labour based on International Labour Organization standards, enforcement priorities and expectations for due diligence, which follow the OECD framework. The Commission also maintains a database of forced labour risks to support companies and authorities.

The decision behind the requirement

EU importers will carry most of the enforcement risk for goods made outside the EU, and they will move that risk upstream. Expect more detailed questionnaires, requests for subcontractor lists and audit reports, and contract clauses on traceability and cooperation.

For a supplier, the cost of answering badly is not a fine but lost business, or an order held while questions are resolved. The suppliers who benefit will be those who can show, without weeks of searching, where each product was made, by whom, and how labour conditions are checked at each tier that matters.

The sound approach is proportionate. Not every input carries the same risk. A supplier should know its highest-risk tiers and materials, have evidence for those, and be honest about where visibility ends.

Five common misreadings

“We have a code of conduct, so we are covered.” A policy is not evidence. Buyers and authorities will look at traceability, audits and how issues are handled.

“The rules apply only to large companies.” The ban applies to products regardless of the size of the company that made or sold them, although enforcement priorities consider size and resources.

“If our due diligence is good, our goods cannot be banned.” Due diligence reduces the risk and helps in an investigation, but it is not a safe harbour.

“Our risk is only in our own factory.” Many risks sit in subcontracted processing, raw materials and seasonal labour further up the chain.

“We have until December 2027.” Buyers are already setting supplier requirements, and building traceability across subcontractors takes time.

Questions for the leadership team

1. Which of our products and inputs carry the highest forced labour risk, and why?
2. Can we trace those products to each processing step and subcontractor?
3. What evidence do we hold on labour conditions at those tiers: audits, worker interviews, grievance channels?
4. How quickly could we answer a detailed traceability request from an EU buyer?
5. Which customer contracts now include forced labour or traceability clauses?
6. How do we handle a suspected issue at a supplier, and who decides?
7. Do we use the Commission’s risk database or other recognised risk sources?
8. Who owns this topic in our business, and does the board see it?

What a good first step produces

A useful first step is a risk and evidence map for the products that carry most of your EU sales. It should show where your highest-risk tiers are, what evidence exists, how fast you can answer a buyer, and what to fix first.

Ganrich Advisory runs this as a focused review with your sourcing, production and sales teams, and works with independent social auditors and legal counsel where audits or formal advice are needed. We do not certify supply chains. We share the working method in a conversation rather than in print, because it depends on the chain.

Start a conversation

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About this paper. This paper reflects official sources checked on 23–24 October 2026. It is general information, not legal, customs, tax or engineering advice. Rules, thresholds and dates change; confirm them against official sources before acting. It describes no client work or results.

Sources: Regulation (EU) 2024/3015 on prohibiting products made with forced labour: eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/reg/2024/3015/oj · European Commission, Guidelines on the Forced Labour Regulation, 30 June 2026 · International Labour Organization, Forced Labour Convention, 1930 (No. 29)

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